SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #1 · GOD

“God is punishing me for my many sins.”

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Where it often comes from

Teaching that every illness, loss, or hardship is God’s punishment for something you did. Parents or caretakers who punished harshly and kept score of every wrong. Real sins from the past that were never fully brought to God, or that were confessed but never felt forgiven. A conscience that keeps a running list of failures. Hearing well-meaning Christians suggest that your trouble must be the result of sin.

What Scripture teaches

Your sins are real, but in Christ they have been dealt with completely. The punishment you deserved fell on Jesus at the cross, and God does not punish the same sin twice. When you confess, He forgives and removes your sin as far as the east is from the west. God does discipline His children, but discipline is a loving father’s training for your good, not payback. Choices can still have natural consequences, and some troubles simply come from living in a broken world. Jesus Himself taught that suffering is not proof of a person’s sin.

> *“He does not treat us as our sins deserve or repay us according to our iniquities. For as high as the heavens are above the earth, so great is his love for those who fear him; as far as the east is from the west, so far has he removed our transgressions from us”* **(Psalm 103:10–12)**.

Also see

> “But he was pierced for our transgressions, he was crushed for our iniquities; the punishment that brought us peace was on him, and by his wounds we are healed” **(Isaiah 53:5)**.

> “If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just and will forgive us our sins and purify us from all unrighteousness” **(1 John 1:9)**.

> “His disciples asked him, ‘Rabbi, who sinned, this man or his parents, that he was born blind?’ ‘Neither this man nor his parents sinned,’ said Jesus, ‘but this happened so that the works of God might be displayed in him.’” **(John 9:2–3)**.

> “God disciplines us for our good, in order that we may share in his holiness. No discipline seems pleasant at the time, but painful. Later on, however, it produces a harvest of righteousness and peace for those who have been trained by it” **(Hebrews 12:10–11)**.

> “Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus” **(Romans 8:1)**.

Common self-statements

- This trouble is God paying me back for what I’ve done.
- I’ve sinned too much to expect anything but punishment.
- Every bad thing that happens is because of my sin.
- God may forgive, but He still makes me pay.
- I deserve this.
- If I had lived better, this wouldn’t be happening.

Common logical errors

- **Personalization:** Assuming that an illness, loss, or setback happened because God is punishing you.
- **Emotional reasoning:** Concluding “I feel guilty, so this must be God’s punishment.”
- **Cause-and-effect error:** Linking a hardship to a past sin with no real evidence that one caused the other.
- **Mental filter:** Remembering every sin you have committed while overlooking God’s promise to forgive and forget them.
- **Overgeneralization:** Treating one hard season as proof that God is always against you.
- **Disqualifying the positive:** Dismissing God’s forgiveness as true for others but not for someone with sins like yours.

Challenging questions

- What is the actual evidence that this hardship is God's punishment?
- If Jesus took the punishment for my sins, what punishment is left for me?
- Have I confessed these sins? If so, why am I still acting as if God is holding them against me?
- Do faithful, godly people also go through hardships like mine?
- Who taught me that God pays people back? Does that make it true?
- Am I confusing God's loving discipline with punishment?
- Could this be a natural consequence, or simply part of living in a broken world, rather than God's anger?

Truth summary

> God is not punishing me for my sins. Jesus took the punishment I deserved, and when I confess, God forgives me and removes my sin as far as the east is from the west. Hardships in my life are not God paying me back. When God corrects me, it is the loving discipline of a Father, for my good. In Christ there is no condemnation for me.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Forgiveness
- Christ, Sacrifice Of
- Confession
- Guilt/Shame
- Sin, Consequences Of
- Suffering

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Sin
- Forgive/Forgiveness
- Suffering
- Trouble/Hardship

Listen: Overcoming Depression

Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "God is punishing me for my many sins"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"God is punishing me for my many sins." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What is the actual evidence that this is God's punishment?
- ☐ If Jesus took my punishment, what punishment is left for me?
- ☐ Have I confessed this sin? Then why am I still carrying it?
- ☐ Do godly people go through hardships like mine?
- ☐ Am I confusing God's discipline with punishment?
- ☐ Could this simply be part of living in a broken world?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Jesus took the punishment for my sins.
- ☐ God does not treat me as my sins deserve.
- ☐ My confessed sins are forgiven and removed.
- ☐ Hardship is not proof that God is punishing me.
- ☐ God's discipline is love, not payback.
- ☐ There is no condemnation for me in Christ Jesus.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **Psalm 103:10–12**
  "He does not treat us as our sins deserve or repay us according to our iniquities. For as high as the heavens are above the earth, so great is his love for those who fear him; as far as the east is from the west, so far has he removed our transgressions from us."
- [ ] **Isaiah 53:5**
  "But he was pierced for our transgressions, he was crushed for our iniquities; the punishment that brought us peace was on him, and by his wounds we are healed."
- [ ] **1 John 1:9**
  "If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just and will forgive us our sins and purify us from all unrighteousness."
- [ ] **John 9:2–3**
  "His disciples asked him, 'Rabbi, who sinned, this man or his parents, that he was born blind?' 'Neither this man nor his parents sinned,' said Jesus, 'but this happened so that the works of God might be displayed in him.'"
- [ ] **Hebrews 12:10–11**
  "God disciplines us for our good, in order that we may share in his holiness. No discipline seems pleasant at the time, but painful. Later on, however, it produces a harvest of righteousness and peace for those who have been trained by it."
- [ ] **Romans 8:1**
  "Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus."

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Evidence log:** Each day, write down one sign of God's mercy toward me (a need met, a kindness received, a burden lifted).
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Psalm 103:12 becomes: "As far as the east is from the west, so far has he removed **Sarah's** transgressions from **her**."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Forgiveness" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Confess one sin to God, once.** Thank Him that it is forgiven, and when the guilt returns, read 1 John 1:9 instead of confessing it again.
- ☐ **When something goes wrong,** write down three ordinary reasons it could have happened before deciding it is punishment.
- ☐ **Make one wrong right,** if you can (an apology or a repair), and then let it go.
- ☐ **Ask a pastor or trusted Christian friend:** "Do you think God punishes forgiven people?" Write down their answer.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "God is punishing me for my many sins": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A sign of God's mercy today
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~God is punishing me for my many sins.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, help me reject the lie that You are punishing me for my sins. Thank You that Jesus took the punishment I deserved and that You have removed my sins as far as the east is from the west. Help me receive Your forgiveness fully, accept Your loving discipline, and stop carrying what You have already taken away. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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